



Civic Meeting Report

2025 Budget Hearings September 5th Segment #1

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MEessJE400U
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Notice: This report is provided by the [Muncie Policy Memo](#) as a public service. This summary is generated automatically using artificial intelligence from public video transcripts, both of which are prone to error. The report is intended to provide an overview of meeting business and an aid to accessing detailed information from the video recording. When accuracy is critical, please refer to the official video recording or approved minutes.

Municipal Meeting Report: Budget Work Sessions

Meeting Date: (Ongoing Municipal Budget Review)

Report Prepared By: Expert Civic Analyst

Document Purpose: Comprehensive summary for community members, local journalists, and policy researchers detailing department budget reviews, funding challenges, personnel requests, and policy debates.

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1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

The transcript begins directly with an ongoing budget review session; no separate statutory public hearing or committee session was called to order immediately prior.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The presiding officer opened the continuation of the municipal/county budget sessions [00:00:17](#).
 - **Attendance Roll Call:**
 - **Present:** Mr. Webb, President Langan, Mr. Mogel, Mr. Hughes, Mr. Chance, [unnamed council member/pyer], Mr. Freeman.
 - **Absent:** None noted during roll call.
 - **Presiding Officer:** President Langan.
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3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** None recorded (continuation of administrative budget hearings).
 - **Approval of Minutes:** None recorded.
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

CASA (Court Appointed Special Advocates) Budget Review

- **Presenter:** Emily Anderson (Court Administrator) and Ashley Solsdeal (CASA Director) [00:01:32](#).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - The CASA program historically relied heavily on grant funding and non-reverting cash balances. As these cash reserves have been depleted, the program must increasingly lean on County General funds [00:01:36](#).
 - **Salary Adjustments:** Adjustments were made to bring staff to mid-external benchmarks. The CASA Director's salary was increased to meet FLSA exemption thresholds to prevent massive accumulation of comp-time liabilities (noting past accumulation of roughly 400 hours/year) [00:02:35](#).
 - **Staff Reductions / Corrections:** Lines 104 and 105 (Volunteer Coordinator and Staff Advocate) were adjusted downward to match midpoint rates (\$43,693 each), reducing total salary requests by \$7,680, with corresponding FICA (\$18,840) and PERF (\$20,640) adjustments [00:05:00](#).

- **Staff Advocates & Stipends:** Due to a post-COVID decline in volunteer recruitment (particularly among retirees), CASA requested a new Staff Advocate position and a stipend policy (\$130/month per case, capped at 4 cases/\$400/month) to incentivize existing qualified staff to handle overflow cases [00:12:02](#).
- **Professional Services (Legal Representation):** CASA requested \$40,000 for a retained local attorney (\$100/hour for 400 hours) to represent CASA's legal interests in complex juvenile courtroom cases [00:18:41](#).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Budget review and adjustments conducted; no formal final roll call vote taken at this stage (part of ongoing work sessions).

Probation User Fees & Department Operations Review

- **Presenter:** Jeff (Chief Probation Officer) and Emily Anderson [00:05:53, 06:01:51].
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Probation user fees have been used for over 20 years to subsidize base salaries and operational expenses (\$200,000/year) to relieve County General pressure, which has severely depleted user fee cash balances [00:52:52](#).
 - The Chief Probation Officer presented a broader vision: reallocating financial pressures to allow user fee balances to fund proactive community-based juvenile diversion programs (e.g., partnering with local nonprofits like *Brothers to Brothers* on East 5th Street) and a high-risk/sex-offender field supervision unit [01:10:43](#).
 - Discussed line-item corrections for support staff and probation officer assistant titles within adult probation [00:53:50](#).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentation and budget worksheet reconciliation; no final vote taken.

Courts & Juvenile Court Capital / Operational Review

- **Presenter:** Emily Anderson and Magistrate Yarnell [01:29:35, 01:33:31].
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Juvenile Courtroom Remodel & Safety:** Presented a \$43,438 Pride Mark quote for juvenile courtroom modifications, including bullet-resistant reinforcement for the judge's bench (Option 2), repositioning attorney tables and witness stands to improve audio/transcription quality, replacing frayed/bubbling original carpeting, and adding security cameras (\$1,444 via YOC) for detention holding blind spots [01:34:36, 01:43:18].
 - **Psychological Evaluations & Interpreters:** Highlighted surging costs and utilization trends for psychological evaluations and certified language interpreters, noting deficits in current budgets [02:13:11](#).
 - **Jury Trials & Chairs:** Noted volatility in jury trial expenses and introduced an equipment request for 70 durable, wipeable jury chairs across five courtrooms (\$23,100 total) [02:16:34, 02:54:01].

- **Judicial LIT Proposal:** Strongly advocated for the adoption of a 0.2% Judicial Local Income Tax (LIT) to generate roughly \$534,906 to fund judicial salaries up to 50% as permitted by state statute, freeing up County General revenue to support underpaid staff and prevent high turnover and staff loss to neighboring competitive counties (Henry and Madison) [02:22:39](#).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Extensive board debate; Council members expressed pushback against new tax options, favoring internal cuts or administrative adjustments. No formal vote taken.

Auditor's Office Budget & Financial Administration Review

- **Presenter:** Ed (County Auditor) and staff [02:56:01](#).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **Salaries & Staffing:** Reviewed internal base salary adjustments, classifications, and proposed salary bumps for claims deputies and finance deputies based on the recent salary study [02:56:30](#).
 - **Auditor & Chief Deputy Salaries:** Addressed the Auditor's salary adjustment based on multi-county comparative averages and the Chief Deputy's salary adjustment (\$58,922) complying with upcoming FLSA threshold increases effective July 1/January 1 [03:00:14](#).
 - **Longevity Pay:** Discussed legacy 62.2% longevity additions rolled into base pay for select longtime employees [03:02:16](#).
 - **Contractual & Professional Services:** Reviewed substantial expenditures for Baker Tilly accounting/financial advisory services (noting ~\$110,000+ annual expenditures plus additional compliance work required by State Board of Accounts mandates) [03:08:35](#).
 - **Grant Coordinator Position:** Proposed a new compliance/grant coordinator position to manage federal/state grant tracking, audit compliance, and revenue acquisition [03:41:38](#).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Review of line items and administrative structures; no formal vote recorded.

Council / General Fund Overviews

- **Presenter:** Council members and administrative staff [03:58:26](#).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Reviewed general fund buffers, office supplies, training/travel allocations, and county council operational expenses [03:58:43](#).
 - Debated the proliferation of stipend lines across departmental budgets versus base salary structures [03:22:01](#).
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** General consensus reached to pause for lunch adjournment [04:11:02](#).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

No general open public comment period or citizen forum was conducted during this administrative budget work session.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - Discussion regarding upcoming software upgrades (Microsoft Office licenses for 18+ computers) 02:49:45.
 - Guidance on submitting formal appropriation requests for security cameras and specific budget transfers in January [02:10:04, 02:27:36].
 - **Adjournment:** The meeting paused for lunch at approximately 04:11:02, with instructions to return for afternoon sessions.
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